



“NO MINISTER EVER STOOD, OR COULD STAND, AGAINST PUBLIC OPINION.”

Robert Peel, British politician, on the Reform Act, 1834

Also during this period, French troops arrived in **Algiers**, with the intention of taking control. A few years earlier, in 1827, the provincial Ottoman ruler, or dey, Husayn (r. 1818–38), had struck a French consul with a fly whisk, giving the French a pretext for war. The source of the tension was an unpaid debt between France and the dey. During a French

#### Liberty leading the people

This famous painting by French artist Eugène Delacroix (1798–1863) was inspired by the July Revolution, and depicts “Liberty” as a woman.



blockade of Algiers, matters escalated. By July 5, the French had raised their flag over the kasbah in Algiers and this marked the start of French control over this North African territory.

In **South America**, political alliances were also fragile. Before his death in 1830, Simón Bolívar (see 1811) had witnessed the secession of **Venezuela and Ecuador** from Gran Colombia, which ended his dream of **political unity** among the new republics.

Farther north, more settlers in the US were making their way west, and this was known as

the **era of the wagon train**.

Settlers, traveling in groups of horse-drawn wagons carrying all of their possessions, headed out to unknown territory to set up farms and settle the land.

Meanwhile, to facilitate settlement in the east, the US government passed the **Indian Removal Act** in 1830. This stripped American Indians of legal rights, and forced them to leave their desirable territory in the southeast of the country and relocate to sparsely populated land west of the Mississippi. The moves resulted in many deaths.

#### THE KINGDOM OF THE NETHERLANDS

was caught up in the turmoil across Europe. The Congress of Vienna (see 1815) had forced the Belgian territories, which had been under French control, to unite with the Dutch, thereby creating a buffer between Russia and France. This move proved unpopular and tensions grew over the intervening years.

By August 1830, inspired by events in France, the **Belgian Revolution** had begun. The result was a clear break from the kingdom of the Netherlands. Later that year a **constitution** was issued, which created a constitutional monarchy and a parliamentary system. On January 20, 1831, the new state of **Belgium** was officially recognized by Britain and France, though not the Netherlands. The Belgians were forced to choose a monarch with no direct connection to other major European powers. They finally elected Leopold of Saxe-Coburg-Saalfeld—the uncle of Britain’s Queen Victoria—and he ruled as **Leopold I** until 1865.

The same year, Syria was annexed by Egypt until 1840, when the latter was finally forced to return the region to the Ottomans.



#### The English Reform Act

A cartoon shows the reformers’ attack on the “Old Rotten Tree,” which symbolizes the corrupt “rotten” boroughs. They wanted a fairer distribution of parliamentary seats.

#### BRITAIN ALSO SAW UPHEAVAL AND SOCIAL CHANGE in the 1830s.

There had been growing public discontent over the outdated voting system (see 1819). A bill was drafted, aimed at transferring votes and redistributing seats from small “rotten” boroughs controlled by the nobility to the more populous industrial towns. The first **Reform Bill** failed to be passed in parliament. This caused serious riots in many cities, as well as a political crisis with the prime minister, **Charles Grey** (1764–1845), who threatened to step down over the matter. The bill finally became law on June 4, 1832. This legislation allowed more middle-class men the vote, but the working class and women were still excluded.

February 7 Belgian constitution recognized; Belgium declares independence

May 26 US Congress passes Indian Removal Act

June 26 William IV (1765–1837) ascends to the British throne

August 9 Louis Philippe (1773–1850) declared king of France after revolution in Paris

First wave of rebellion and social unrest in Europe calling for liberal political reforms

August 25 Start of the Belgian Revolution (to 1831)

November 29 Polish uprising against Russia

Egypt occupies Syria (to 1840)

August 21 Nat Turner slave rebellion in US, leaving more than 50 white people in Virginia dead

June 4 British parliament passes the Reform Act, which makes significant changes to the electoral system

August 30 Treaty of London creates an independent kingdom of Greece and installs a monarchy.

Russia annexes Duchy of Warsaw